
Not Today, Explosive Diarrhea. Not Today.

Published by

Ian Prasad Philbrick

Estimated reading time

5 min

Added on

2026-07-20

Address

<https://slate.com/news-and-politics/2026/07/how-can-i-avoid-cyclospora.html>

Not Today, Explosive Diarrhea. Not Today.

This story is adapted from the Slate newsletter. You can [sign up here](#) to get it in your inbox every day.

An unpleasant sensation is sweeping the nation: vomiting and explosive diarrhea that can last for weeks. Caused by *Cyclospora*, a foodborne parasite, the outbreak has spread to at least 34 states. But public health officials finally appear to be zeroing in on what's causing it. Here's what we know—plus some tips for enjoying a weekend free of gastrointestinal distress.

Gross. Where does this outbreak seem to be coming from?

At first it was a mystery. But now public health officials are eyeing lettuce—specifically shredded iceberg that Taylor Farms, a California-based vegetable supplier, distributed to Taco Bell restaurants in at least five states. Taylor Farms said today that it would [recall certain products](#) after hearing from the Food and Drug Administration. Officials who spoke to the New York Times say a single supplier in Mexico originally grew the offending produce.

How bad is the outbreak?

If you're unlucky enough to have gotten the bug yourself, pretty bad! The illness generally isn't deadly, but diarrhea—which if untreated may last a month—can cause dangerous dehydration. In terms of case numbers, things aren't much better. This is already the U.S.'s largest recorded outbreak of cyclosporiasis, the hard-to-pronounce illness *Cyclospora* causes. According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, more than 1,600 people fell ill after eating at Taco Bell; we know of at least 141 who have been hospitalized. Michigan, the hardest-hit state, reports more than 5,000 cases—nearly twice the number of people who get the parasite nationwide in an average year. And because of incomplete reporting, that's almost certainly an undercount.

How does something like this happen?

Foodborne disease outbreaks caused by viruses, bacteria like *E. coli*, or microscopic parasites like *Cyclospora* are fairly regular occurrences. Cases often rise in the summer and, as my colleague Nadira Goffe explains, frequently [trace back to leafy greens](#). Cyclosporiasis comes from food that's gotten contaminated with human feces while being washed in fields or processing plants.

I very much do not want this. Should I just avoid Taco Bell?

That might not hurt, especially if you live in one of the states where Taylor Farms is suspected to have sent its wares: Indiana, Kentucky, Michigan, Ohio, and West Virginia. But as the food microbiologist Lee-Ann Jaykus told Nadira, it's also possible contaminated lettuce ended up elsewhere—or even that there's more than one outbreak happening at once. If you're really worried, skip uncooked produce like salad mixes, berries, basil, and snap peas for the time being. Washing or peeling can lessen the risk of infection, but cooking food to at least 158 degrees reliably kills *Cyclospora*.

And now the perennial question: Is this Donald Trump's fault?

Not directly, but not not. As Slate's What Next podcast [recently explained](#), the president's two-front war on science and the federal bureaucracy probably hasn't helped. Personnel cuts and leadership turmoil at the CDC and FDA might be hindering those agencies' response to the outbreak. Until this week, states like Michigan [had largely taken the lead](#) on tracking cases.

When will we be rid of this pestilence?

It can take weeks to develop symptoms after getting infected with *Cyclospora*. So even with a possible culprit identified, the outbreak may get bigger before it gets smaller. The CDC says case counts could keep rising into August. Happy summer!

Before we transition, a quick note: As I said in [yesterday's newsletter](#), I watch Trump speeches so you don't have to. As expected, it was a lot of nonsense with some ugly implications: The president spouted unfounded conspiracy theories as part of an ongoing campaign to make it more difficult to vote. I covered the many dubious claims Trump made—and some notable ones he didn't—[here](#).





Tolga Akdoğan

OK, you're caught up. But between parasitic infections and the wildfire smoke that's currently choking U.S. cities, maybe you'd prefer to spend much of this weekend inside. If so, we recommend:

Plan your weekend viewing: Heading to the movies and wondering what to see? If you're anything like me, you're psyched for Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey*, an adaptation of Homer's epic poem. My colleague Dana Stevens says it may be [her favorite Nolan movie to date](#). And if that's not quite your thing, here's what Slate critics thought of several other movies that are still playing in theaters: [The Invite](#), [Supergirl](#), [Minions & Monsters](#), [Toy Story 5](#), [Disclosure Day](#), and [Obsession](#).

If you do go out, however ... beat the heat with a parasol: In the middle of a brutally hot summer, the humble parasol can offer sweet relief in the form of your own private patch of shade. It's also better, cheaper, and more effective than sunscreen. If you're not using one, [you're missing out](#).

And enjoy a hangover-free night out: It's now possible to drink all night and wake up feeling like you're 25 again. If you want to party without regrets, consider sipping on lower-booze spirits and cocktails, which contain a fraction of traditional beverages' ABV. [Cheers!](#)

See how your news knowledge stacks up: You might know Slate features writer Alexander Sammon from the time he [took a spam texter's job offer](#), or the time he investigated [the fate of the Florida orange](#), or the time he went [surfing in a mall](#) and reflected on it as an allegory for the

American dream. But can you beat his score [in our weekly news quiz](#)?

OK, time for me to dip out so we can all enjoy a couple of well-deserved days off. See you Monday!

Get the best of news and politics

Sign up for Slate's evening newsletter.

Thanks for signing up! You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

You're already subscribed to the The Slatest newsletter. You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

We encountered an issue signing you up. Please try again, or [manage all your newsletter subscriptions here](#) .

Please enable javascript to sign up for newsletters.

Email address:

Send me updates about Slate special offers.

By signing up, you agree to our [Privacy Policy](#) and [Terms](#).

Sign Up

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.